Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

Is Hospitality Safe From AI?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

4.0

AI EXPOSURE · HEAD CHEF / KITCHEN LEADERSHIP

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open with a risk number, they either get frightened and shut down, or defensive about a decision they've already made.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation.

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And two things specific to hospitality.

First, this is the profile that inverts the pattern running through the rest of this index. In law, finance, business and software, the entry tier is collapsing and the senior end is holding. In hospitality the opposite is happening: entry-level hiring has eased, and the acute shortage is now in experienced leadership — general managers, executive chefs, district managers.

Second, if your reaction to "hospitality" is that it isn't a real career, that's worth examining before the conversation. It employs two million more people than it did in 2020, the chef population has grown nearly 80%, and general manager salaries rose over 12% in a single year. The honest problems here are real — and they are about conditions, not about prospects.

The short answer

Yes for hands-on service and culinary work — and hospitality has the healthiest progression picture of any career in this index.

Housekeeping and facilities scores **3.0** out of 10. Culinary and kitchen work scores **3.2.** Front-of-house service scores **3.6.** Reservations and customer service administration scores **7.4.**

The protection is straightforward: **the guest experience is the product, and it happens in a physical place, to a person, in real time.**

The honest problem is equally straightforward, and it's the highest turnover of any industry in the United States.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Housekeeping & facilities	2.6	2.8	**3.0**	+0.4	Low
Culinary & kitchen	2.7	3.0	**3.2**	+0.5	Low
Front-of-house service	3.1	3.4	**3.6**	+0.5	Low
Event operations	3.8	4.1	**4.4**	+0.6	Low–Moderate
Hotel & venue management	4.1	4.5	**4.8**	+0.7	Moderate
Revenue management & pricing	5.4	6.1	**6.6**	+1.2	Moderate–High
Reservations & customer service admin	6.2	6.9	**7.4**	+1.2	High

Scores run 1–10, *where* 10 *is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around* 5.5, *a service electrician scores* 2.5, *bedside nursing* 2.8, *and a business analyst* 7.6.

Read the table this way: everything that happens in front of a guest scores below 4.4. Everything that happens in an office behind them scores above 6.6.

Hospitality inverts the pattern in this index

This is the most useful finding here, and it runs opposite to almost every other profile we've written.

Across this index, the story has been consistent: AI absorbs junior work, employers hire experience instead of building it, and the on-ramp narrows while the profession stays healthy. Junior law rates 9.5 on entry-path erosion. Entry software rates 9.0. Business rates 7.5.

Hospitality is the reverse, and the data is unusually direct.

Industry salary analysis for 2026 reports that the biggest hiring challenge is no longer entry-level roles — it is experienced leadership: general managers, executive chefs and district managers. Entry-level labour availability has improved. Hourly wage growth has moderated to 1–3%.

Meanwhile general manager salaries rose **12.24% year-on-year**.

Why this happens is worth understanding. Hospitality's junior work is physical and guest-facing — making the food, cleaning the room, serving the table. None of it was ever automatable in the way that document review or spreadsheet building was, so the entry rung was never at risk. What thinned instead was the pipeline of people staying long enough to become experienced operators.

So the shortage is a retention artefact rather than an automation one. Seventy to eighty per cent of the workforce turns over annually, most of it voluntary — which means very few people accumulate the ten years that make a general manager.

The general lesson: an industry that cannot retain people will eventually have a leadership shortage regardless of how many people it hires. Hospitality is that outcome, arriving now, and it is unusually good news for anyone willing to stay.

Why service work holds — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	**5.5**
How hard will it be to land that first job?	**2.5**
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	**9.0**
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	**7.0**
Does the law require a licensed human?	**2.0**
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	**6.0**

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how front-of-house service answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

The booking, the scheduling and the pricing. Not the service.

Reservations and booking management. Revenue management and dynamic pricing. Shift scheduling and rota optimisation. Inventory and ordering. Guest communication and confirmations. Review monitoring and response drafting.

Revenue management is the clearest case: pricing rooms against demand, competitor rates and seasonality is a constrained optimisation problem with structured inputs, and it used to be a skilled career.

What resists: cooking the food, cleaning the room, reading a table, recovering a guest whose evening has gone wrong, and running a service when three things fail at once.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

The easiest entry we measure anywhere. The American Hotel and Lodging Association reports **76% of hotels operating short-staffed**, with the most acute gaps in housekeeping, front desk, culinary and maintenance. No degree required, training is on the job, and over 60% of hospitality businesses report difficulty finding candidates.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Entirely. The guest is physically present and the experience is the product.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Moderately, and it rises sharply with seniority. A guest doesn't need a specific server; a hotel owner absolutely needs a specific general manager.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Partially — food safety certification, alcohol licensing, fire and health compliance all require qualified people. Real but lighter than in healthcare or construction.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Constantly in operations. Service is a sequence of unscripted problems under time pressure, which is exactly what automation handles worst.

What the trend shows

Culinary and kitchen work: 2.7 → 3.0 → 3.2. Up 0.5 in three years.

Reservations and administration: 6.2 → 6.9 → 7.4. Up 1.2.

The gap widened from 3.5 points to 4.2 — one of the widest in the index. The office half of hospitality is moving nearly two and a half times as fast as the operational half.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Physical / embodied	Very strong	**Durable**	The guest is physically present. Kitchen and housekeeping robotics exist but are expensive, inflexible and limited to high-volume standardised settings.
Judgment under novelty	Strong in operations	**Durable**	Service is unscripted problem-solving under time pressure.
Human trust / accountability	Rises with seniority	**Durable at management level**	An owner needs a specific, accountable operator.
Regulatory / licensing	Partial	**Moderate**	Food safety, alcohol and fire compliance require certified people.

The honest read. Hospitality's protection is unusually simple and unusually solid: the product is an experience delivered to a physically present person. That doesn't automate, and the parts that do — booking, pricing, scheduling — were never the job.

The one thing to watch is the same pattern as elsewhere: standardised, high-volume settings automate first. Quick-service kitchens with limited menus are a more automatable environment than a full-service restaurant, in exactly the way a prefabrication factory is more automatable than a building site.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Taking reservations	Automated
Setting room rates	Revenue systems price it; managers judge exceptions
Building the rota	Optimised automatically
Ordering and stock control	Automated
Responding to reviews	Drafted, then edited
Cooking the food	**Unchanged**
Reading a room and recovering a bad night	**Unchanged**
Running a service when three things go wrong	**Unchanged**

The automation here is landing almost entirely on the administrative layer, which in hospitality was never the craft. That makes it one of the more straightforwardly positive pictures in this index — with the caveat that the administrative roles it removes were genuine careers for some people.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Running a service under pressure** — the unscripted problem-solving that is the actual job. 2. **Reading people** — the table that's unhappy before anyone says so, the guest who needs

> something they haven't asked for.

3. **Cooking and craft** — physical skill built over years, and the reason chef numbers have

> grown.

4. **Leading a team through a shift** — hospitality is managed in real time, not in advance. 5. **Recovery** — turning a bad experience around, which is consistently what guests remember.

Notably absent: booking management, rate setting and rota building. These were meaningful parts of a hospitality career and are the fastest-depreciating.

Other things to consider

What's genuinely good about it

The employment growth is substantial and often overlooked. Between 2020 and 2024, the hospitality workforce grew by over two million people — around 23.7%. Within that:

- **Chefs grew 79.6%** — from 101,490 to 182,320
- Bartenders grew 53.2%
- Bakers grew 37.3%
- Cooks grew 30.9%

Progression is fast and merit-based. Hospitality is one of very few fields where someone can start with no qualification at eighteen and be running a venue at twenty-six. There is no licence gate, no degree requirement, and advancement runs on demonstrated competence.

And the leadership shortage is the opportunity. With GM salaries up 12.24% year-on-year and experienced operators the hardest roles to fill, the person who stays long enough to become one is entering a genuinely under-supplied market.

Ownership is a normal destination, and the skills transfer internationally more easily than almost any career in this index.

What people report as rewarding: immediate feedback — you know within the hour whether it went well; genuine team culture under pressure; creativity in culinary work; and variety.

What's genuinely hard about it

The turnover is the highest of any industry in the United States, and it defines the sector.

- Annual turnover in accommodation and food services runs **70–80%** — roughly **five times** the 12–15% typical of other industries

- The quit rate reached **4.3% per month** in March 2026 — the highest of any industry BLS tracks, and nearly double the private-sector average of 2.2%
- **Around three-quarters of separations are voluntary.** Layoffs sit at 1.3%, matching the national average — so this is people leaving, not being let go.

And the research on *why* is unusually clear, and it isn't only pay.

Wage competitiveness is the most-cited driver. But **schedule unpredictability ranks equally or higher** in surveys of people who left — irregular shift notice, last-minute cancellations, and hours that make budgeting impossible.

And manager quality is the single strongest predictor of voluntary turnover in hospitality research. The relationship between an hourly employee and their direct supervisor predicts whether they stay better than anything else.

That finding is unusually actionable, and section 10 returns to it.

Pay at the entry level is modest and wage growth has stalled — hourly wages grew just 1–3% in 2026 as the post-pandemic premiums dissipated.

And the employment picture has genuine soft spots. Eating and drinking places lost a net 32,900 jobs in June 2026, full-service restaurant employment remains 174,000 jobs below pre-pandemic levels, and independent restaurants declined 2.3% in 2025.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Hospitality tends to suit people who:

- **Get energy from other people** rather than being drained by them, for whole shifts
- **Perform well under time pressure** — service is a sustained sprint
- **Want immediate feedback** on whether they did well
- **Are physically robust** — these are long shifts on your feet
- **Want to run something** — the route to management and ownership is unusually short

It's harder for people who:

- Need **predictable schedules** — this is the number one reason people leave
- Want **weekends and evenings free** — those are the working hours
- Find **rudeness draining** — guests are not always reasonable

- Assume it's a **temporary job.** It can be. The people who do well are the ones who decided it wasn't.

What else is moving this market

The labour shortfall is structural — AHLA forecasts an 18% shortfall through 2026, driven by fewer young workers entering the sector and immigration policy compressing an existing pipeline.

Labour costs are rising faster than revenue. US hotels will pay **$131 billion** in wages and benefits in 2026, 15.3% above 2019, against operating revenue growth of only 12.8% over the same period. That pressure is real and it shapes how operators behave.

And regional variation is large — Washington DC, New York and Massachusetts run 15–25% above national averages.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: the automation in hospitality is landing on the back office, and the shortage is in experienced operators. That points to an unusually clear strategy.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE HOSPITALITY PROFESSIONAL LOOKS LIKE

1. Stay long enough to become experienced. This is the whole strategy. With 70–80% annual turnover, the market for people with ten years of operational experience is severely undersupplied, and GM pay is rising 12% a year to prove it.

2. Learn the systems that are replacing the back office. Revenue management platforms, scheduling optimisation, inventory systems. Understanding what the system is doing — and when it's wrong — is what separates a manager from an operator.

3. Judge the exceptions. Dynamic pricing handles normal weeks. It handles a citywide event, a weather closure or a reputational incident badly. That judgment is the job.

4. Manage people well, deliberately. Since manager quality is the strongest predictor of whether staff stay, a manager who can retain a team in an industry that loses 74% of its people annually is delivering measurable financial value — replacement costs run 30–50% of salary per departure.

5. Understand the unit economics. Labour costs are outgrowing revenue. Operators who can read a P&L are the ones who get promoted.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before committing: work a full season, including a bad one — a Christmas period, a summer peak, a difficult service. Hospitality is romanticised and the reality is physical and relentless. It also suits some people completely.

Choosing an employer: ask about turnover and scheduling practice specifically. Given that schedule unpredictability and manager quality are the top two drivers of people leaving, those two questions predict whether the job is sustainable.

And be deliberate about the ladder. The route from line cook to head chef, or from front desk to GM, is genuinely open — but only to people who plan it.

The routes in

ROUTE	ASSESSMENT
Direct entry → operational progression	No qualification needed, and the ladder is real. The most common route to management.
Culinary training / apprenticeship	Structured craft skill. Chef numbers grew 79.6% since 2020.
Hospitality management degree	Useful for corporate and multi-site roles; not required for operational progression.
Events and venue operations	Scores 4.4, and the skills transfer broadly.
Revenue management / reservations	The exposed end at 6.6–7.4, despite sounding like the professional route.

Where hospitality can lead later

Venue and hotel management, multi-site and district leadership, executive chef and culinary direction, food and beverage direction, events and venue ownership, hotel operations and asset management, franchising, and business ownership.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from the guest, the higher the exposure. Revenue management and reservations score 6.6 and 7.4, against operations at 3.0–4.8 — and they are the roles that look like promotions off the floor.

What to look for in an employer

1. Turnover rate. The most informative number in this industry and the least advertised.

2. Scheduling practice. How much notice, and how often are shifts changed? This is the second-biggest reason people leave.

3. Manager quality and training. Ask who you'd report to and how they were developed. It is the strongest predictor of whether you stay.

4. Progression evidence. Who was promoted from within in the last two years, and to what?

5. Property type. Full-service hotels typically run 40–60% turnover against quick-service restaurants at the top of the 70–80% range.

Questions to ask an employer

- What's your annual turnover rate for this role?
- How much notice do staff get for shifts, and how often do they change?
- Who would I report to, and how long have they been here?
- Who's been promoted from within in the last two years?
- What training exists beyond the first month?
- What certifications do you fund — food safety, alcohol, first aid?

Red flags: evasiveness about turnover; scheduling described as "flexible" without detail; no internal promotions to point to; training that stops after induction.

Go deeper — further reading

- **BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. The primary source for the turnover and quit-rate figures. Accommodation and food services is consistently the highest of any industry tracked, and seeing that in the government's own data is more persuasive than any commentary.

- **AHLA State of the Industry** — *American Hotel and Lodging Association*. The 76%-short-staffed figure, the labour shortfall forecast and the wage-cost data. Read it knowing AHLA represents hotel operators.
- **National Restaurant Association research** — employment tracking by segment, including the full-service recovery data. Useful for seeing which parts of the sector are actually growing.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our scores isn't that robots will cook the food. It's that a low AI score may lead someone to under-weight the thing that actually ends hospitality careers: the conditions.
>
> Annual turnover of 70–80%, the highest quit rate of any US industry, three-quarters of departures voluntary, and wage growth that has flattened to 1–3%. On this reading, telling a seventeen-year-old that hospitality is "protected from AI" is true and close to irrelevant — the risk here was never automation, and the sector loses most of its people within a year regardless.
>
> There's a second, more specific challenge too: quick-service and high-volume standardised kitchens are a genuinely more automatable environment than we may be crediting, and that is where a large share of entry-level hospitality employment sits.
>
> **Where we land:** both are fair. Our score measures automation exposure and nothing else, and for hospitality the technology answer is straightforwardly good and the conditions answer is the hard one. That's why section 8 is the longest here, and why the practical advice is about choosing an employer rather than choosing the industry.

Bottom line

Hospitality is well protected from automation and it inverts the pattern in this index.

Everything in front of a guest scores below 4.4 — the experience is the product and it happens in a physical place, in real time, to a person. Everything behind them scores above 6.6, because booking, pricing and scheduling are structured problems that were never the craft.

And unusually, the entry tier is not the problem here. Across this index the on-ramp is narrowing while professions stay healthy. In hospitality the on-ramp is wide open — 76% of hotels are short-staffed — and the shortage has moved *up* to experienced leadership, with GM salaries rising 12.24% in a year.

The honest problem is retention, and it is severe. Turnover of 70–80% annually, five times the norm, with the highest quit rate of any industry BLS tracks and three-quarters of departures voluntary.

Which produces an unusually clear strategy: the value is in staying. In an industry that loses most of its people within a year, the person who accumulates a decade of operational experience is entering a severely undersupplied market.

So the useful advice is: choose the employer far more carefully than the industry — ask about turnover and scheduling, because schedule unpredictability and manager quality are the two biggest reasons people leave. Aim at operations rather than the back office, because revenue management and reservations look like promotions and score twice as high. Learn the systems well enough to judge their exceptions. And work a bad season before committing.

And one thing worth saying to a parent whose first reaction was that this isn't a real career. It employs two million more people than it did in 2020, the chef population has grown nearly 80%, and it is one of very few fields where someone can start at eighteen with no qualification and be running a venue at twenty-six. The problems here are real and they are about conditions, not about ceilings.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made hospitality appealing? Push past "I like people" to something specific. 2. **Do they want to cook, to serve, or to run something?** Three different careers with

> different paths.

3. How do they perform under sustained time pressure? Service is a long sprint. 4. Have they worked a difficult service — a Christmas period, a summer peak?

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Kitchen work scores 3.2 and reservations administration 7.4. Does that change where they'd

> aim?

6. **In most careers the entry tier is collapsing; in hospitality the shortage is at the top.**

> What do they make of that?

7. Chef numbers grew 79.6% between 2020 and 2024. Was that surprising?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. **Turnover runs 70–80%, five times the norm, and three-quarters of it is voluntary.** What

> would make them one of the people who stays?

9. Schedule unpredictability is one of the top reasons people leave. Is that something they could

> live with?

10. Evenings, weekends and holidays are the working hours. Have they pictured that over ten years?

Part 2c — The other side

11. GM salaries rose 12.24% in a year and experienced operators are the hardest roles to fill.

> Does the progression picture look different from the entry pay?

12. Of what's rewarding — immediate feedback, team culture, creativity, variety, a short route to

> running something — which two matter most?

13. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then

> compare.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

14. Revenue management and reservations are automating. Does it change anything to know those are

> the roles that look like promotions off the floor?

15. Manager quality is the strongest predictor of whether staff stay. What kind of manager would

> they want to be?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

16. **The most valuable single action:** work a full season including a hard one. Hospitality is

> romanticised, and a bad Saturday night answers the question quickly.

17. Find someone who's been in hospitality ten years and ask what kept them — and someone who left

> after one, and ask what didn't.

Part 4 — About the employer

18. Ask the turnover and scheduling questions from section 14. They predict sustainability better

> than pay does.

19. Who's been promoted from within in the last two years?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

20. Have they considered **culinary training or apprenticeship** specifically? Structured craft,

> and chef numbers are growing fast.

21. What about **events and venue operations**? Scores 4.4 and the skills transfer broadly. 22. If hospitality weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals whether

> the pull is people, pressure, food or independence.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

23. **What was my honest first reaction to this?** Was it about their prospects or about status? 24. Do I know that this sector employs two million more people than in 2020, or was I assuming

> decline?

25. Am I worried about the hours and the pay — and have I said so clearly rather than hinting? 26. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For hospitality specifically, we've flagged that the sector's defining risk is retention rather than automation, that our framework cannot see working conditions, and that standardised high-volume settings are more automatable than the full-service environments this profile is largely describing.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Hospitality

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

```
Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No licence exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

HOUSEKEEPING & FACILITIES — 3.0 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	1.9	2.4	**2.9**	1.01
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.5	1.8	**2.0**	0.3
Physical / embodied	15%	9.5	9.5	**9.5**	0.07
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.35
				Total	**3.02 → 3.0**

CULINARY & KITCHEN — 3.2 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	3.3	4.0	**4.5**	1.57
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.5	1.8	**2.0**	0.3
Physical / embodied	15%	9.5	9.5	**9.5**	0.07
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.4
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**3.2 → 3.2**

FRONT-OF-HOUSE SERVICE — 3.6 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.1	4.9	**5.4**	1.89
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.8	2.0	**2.2**	0.33
Physical / embodied	15%	9.3	9.3	**9.3**	0.1
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**3.6 → 3.6**

EVENT OPERATIONS — 4.4 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	6.2	**7.0**	2.45
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.5	2.8	**3.0**	0.45
Physical / embodied	15%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.3
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.55
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.4 → 4.4**

HOTEL & VENUE MANAGEMENT — 4.8 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	7.0	**7.7**	2.69
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	**3.8**	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.79 → 4.8**

REVENUE MANAGEMENT & PRICING — 6.6 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	5.8	**7.0**	2.45
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	**5.5**	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	**2.0**	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
				Total	**6.6 → 6.6**

RESERVATIONS & CUSTOMER SERVICE ADMIN — 7.4 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.6	7.3	**8.5**	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.6	**6.2**	0.93
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	**2.0**	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
				Total	**7.4 → 7.4**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Housekeeping & facilities

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	1.9	1.5	1.7	**2.6**
2025	2.4	1.8	1.7	**2.8**
Fall 2026	2.9	2.0	1.7	**3.0**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.35** and entry-path erosion **+0.07**, for a total of **+0.4** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labour market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

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7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.